Do Proximal Reasons for Homelessness Predict Observed Parenting Quality in Shelters?

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Abstract

The relationship between coming to a shelter and problem solving skills based on a parent-child interaction task were examined using data from 138 children and their parents staying in an emergency shelter. Reasons for coming to the shelter and parent-child interaction tasks were studied in order to assess whether parenting quality relates to the reasons for coming to the homeless shelter. Results indicated that reasons generally were not related to effective parenting; only one reason (left by person supporting me) was related to parenting and this association was positive. Based on the percentage of parents who endorsed specific reasons, it was found that more parents came to the shelter for financial reasons compared to relationship reasons.

Background

- Developmental theories of parenting suggest that financial and relationship stress interfere with effective parenting (Lee, Lee, & August, 2011)
- Studies find that financial strain and interpersonal relationship problems are risk factors for parenting problems (Conger, Conger, & Martin, 2010)
- Severe financial and interpersonal stress are common among homeless families (Swick & Williams, 2010)

Goals of Study

- Examine the reasons parents report for homelessness
- Examine whether specific reasons are related to observed quality of parenting during a shelter stay

Hypotheses

- Financial stressors and interpersonal problems will be common reasons for current homelessness reported by parents currently living in an emergency shelter
- Financial and interpersonal adversity reasons for homelessness will be associated with less effective parenting observed in a structured parent-child interaction session

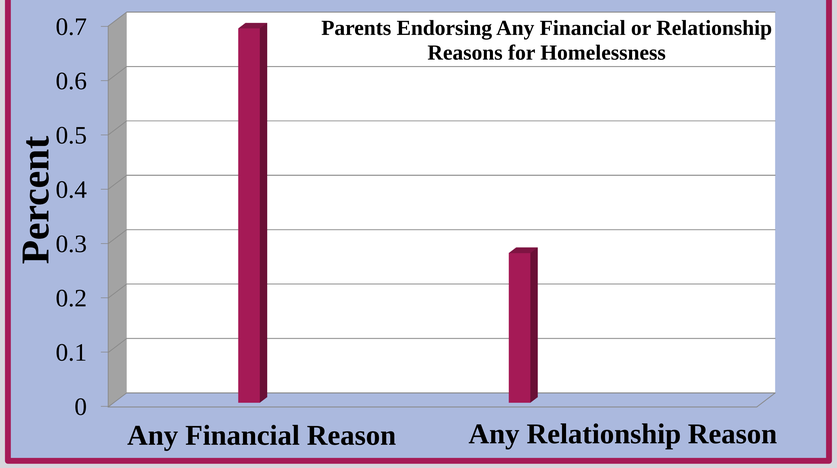
Table 1: Selected Reasons of Homelessness: Financial and Relationships	Percent of Parent Endorsing Reason	Percent Endorsing as Most Important Reason
Could not find a place you could afford	48%	9%
Voluntary move to a different city/state	43%	6%
No longer able to afford rent	24%	9%
Relationship problems	23%	4%
Battering, abusive relationship	15%	7%
Fired from job	15%	6%
Laid off from job	15%	4%
Rise in rent	12%	1%
Foreclosure on home rented	9%	2%
Lease was not renewed	7%	1%
Foreclosure on home owned	2%	2%
Other	24%	24%



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Table 2: Most Important Reason by Broad Category	
Financial	36%
Relationship	12%
Other	51%





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Methods

Participants and Procedures

- 138 families with a child entering kindergarten or first grade staying in an emergency shelter
- Child ethnicities identified included 66.6% African American, 15.9% Multiracial, 6.5% American Indian, 4.3% Asian, 1.4% as Somali, and 2.8% as Other
- Parent ethnicities identified included 63.7% African American, 10.9% Multiracial, 7.2% American Indian, 2.2% Asian, 1.4% Somali and 2.9% Other
- Families completed a single session that included a parent interview, child testing, and structured parent-child interaction

Measures

- Family interviews included a checklist of reasons for homelessness; parents also identified the "most important reason"
- Parent-Child Interaction video was later coded for parenting quality using the system developed for PMTO – Parent Management Training – Oregon Model by Forgatch and colleagues, including a Problem-Solving score

Results

- ***Coding Reliability*** - Interclass coefficient for the problems solving score was .81, indicating excellent agreement among coders
- ***Percent Endorsement of Reasons*** – see Table 1
- ***Most Important Reason*** – see Table 2
- Only for one reason did the mean for endorsers differ from, non-endorsers, for "Left by a person supporting me" – which indicated better parenting among endorsers (2.49 versus 2.00, t = -2.367, p < .05)

Conclusion

- Financial reasons, not surprisingly, comprise the most commonly endorsed reasons for homelessness by parents in an emergency shelter
- The reason "Other" was commonly selected was because participants were able to define "Other" as an open-ended answer (i.e., health, housing conditions, etc.)
- Reasons for homelessness generally were not related to parenting quality
- Other risk and protective influences may be more important for parenting than the proximal reasons for homelessness, such as a parent's coping skills or social support

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